The Qin Dynasty

With the declaration as First Emperor, Shi Huangdi founded the Qin Dynasty, which lasted between 221 and 206 BCE. The Qin Dynasty was technically the fourth dynasty but is known as the first Imperial Dynasty in Chinese history. Shi Huangdi is famous for tearing down the fortified walls that once separated the various states. He joined them together to create a single defensive structure to protect his territory from invading nomads. This defensive structure later became known as the Great Wall of China. The original wall built by the First Emperor was much smaller than the one that exists today. Later dynasties came and continued to build the wall, until it became a highly attractive tourist attraction. Shi Huangdi also made great contributions to society through the construction of roads, bridges and buildings. He expanded the borders, began the construction of the Grand Canal in southern China, reallocated lands and tried his best to act justly with the people.

Despite the great building projects and his military victories, Shi Huangdi soon found himself being resented by the people due to his strict policies. Declaring that he possessed the Mandate of Heaven, the First Emperor banned all philosophies of the day except for Legalism, which had been put forward by Shang Yang. He burned all historical and philosophical books which did not reflect his family, the state, or Legalism. The people no longer had any freedom to speak against the beliefs he propagated. If a group of people spoke up against him, they were quickly isolated and shunned by those under Shi Huangdi’s command.

Near the later part of his life, the First Emperor began to concentrate more on his afterlife and spirituality. He was seeking ways to gain immortality. He began the construction of a lavish palace from terracotta inside his tomb and ordered 8,000 warriors to guard his resting place. Ironically, he consumed an elixir which did not give him eternal life but instead took it from him. It is generally accepted among historians that he died from mercury poisoning.